

Avora — Experience Architecture

How the Engine Becomes the Heart

0. The governing rule

Everything visible in the town is a **record of something real**, never a representation of app usage. If it can be earned by opening Avora more, it doesn't belong. If it can only exist because a life actually happened — a goal finished, a season endured, a rest taken — it belongs.

The test for every mechanic in this document: *could this exist if the person never looked at their phone again after doing the real thing?* If yes, keep it. If the town needs you to check in to "claim" it, cut it.

1. What the town actually is

Not a game layer bolted onto a productivity tool. A **visual autobiography** — the place where a life, lived, becomes something you can walk through and recognize yourself in.

The Engine holds the *record*. The Brain finds the *meaning*. The Town holds the *memory*. A goal completed in the Engine isn't "data" that gets rendered into a building — it's

the same event, seen from far enough away to feel like a place instead of a checklist.

2. Districts, not menus

Life areas don't map 1:1 onto neighborhoods like a settings page. They cluster the way life actually clusters — by *feeling*, not by category:

- **The Hearth** — home, meals, pets. Warm, domestic, low-lit windows, smoke from a chimney on a day you actually cooked.
- **The Grove** — health, rest, body. Organic, slow-growing, seasonal by nature — this district is allowed to go dormant in winter without it meaning anything went wrong.
- **The Harbor** — work, travel. Movement, arrivals and departures — ships in dock represent trips taken, not trips planned.
- **The Library** — reading, notes, learning. Quiet, accumulates slowly, one shelf at a time.
- **The Square** — relationships. The only district that can't grow from solo effort — it changes when *time with other people* actually happens.
- **Finance** deliberately has no district. It's the ground the town is built on — visible as the town's overall stability and light, never as its own set of buildings. Money is infrastructure, not identity.

Districts aren't chosen from a menu on day one. They emerge — the first time you complete something in an area, its district quietly appears on the skyline. An empty life area is simply empty ground. Not a locked door, not a nagging "start here" sign.

3. How a goal becomes a landmark

A landmark is never awarded on completion like a trophy. It's **grown**:

1. When a goal is set, its future site appears as a foundation stone — barely visible, easy to miss, exactly as uncertain as a new goal actually is.
2. As real progress happens (not app opens — actual linked activity: a task done, a session logged, a trip taken), the structure fills in incrementally. Slowly. A goal worked on for three months looks like three months of construction, not a bar filling up.
3. On completion, nothing bursts or flashes. Next time you open the town, the structure is simply *finished* — standing there, permanent, the way a real accomplishment sits quietly in your life until you happen to notice it again.
4. Not every completed task earns a landmark. Only what the person or the Brain flags as *meaningful* — the Brain can propose ("this feels like one worth remembering"), but the person always has final say. This keeps landmarks rare enough to mean something.

Landmarks never disappear. Once earned, permanent — regardless of what happens in the district around them later.

4. Representing failure — or rather, not

There is no decay mechanic. No wilting, no cracking, no "your garden is dying" guilt engine. That entire genre of app — the one that punishes you for not opening it — is the thing Avora exists to not be.

An unfinished goal's foundation stone simply... stays a foundation stone. Unremarkable. No visual judgment. It waits exactly as long as the goal is still alive to you.

If a goal is genuinely abandoned — not lapsed, *abandoned*, and only when the person says so — its site doesn't rot. It gently returns to open ground. No monument to failure. The town doesn't remember what you decided not to finish; it only remembers what you did.

5. Representing rest

Rest gets its own visual language — not the absence of activity, its own deliberate state:

- A dormant district doesn't look neglected. It looks like a garden lying fallow — quieter light, softer color, maybe stars out over it at night. Fallow ground is *healthy* farming, not failed farming, and the town should read that way at a glance.

- If someone logs real rest (a day off actually taken, sleep, a declared "nothing" day), that's not punished by silence — it can *quietly* register as its own small, warm event. Rest is a thing that happened, same as anything else that happened.
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6. Time — days, months, years

- **Day to day:** ambient life, not progress bars. A lit window if you did something small today. Weather that drifts with real-world weather or mood, not a countdown.
- **Week to week:** districts visibly, slowly densify with real activity. Nothing dramatic — the kind of change you'd only notice if you compared two weeks side by side.
- **Month to month:** whole districts can shift character based on where real life has actually gone — a season of heavy work makes the Harbor busier; a season of rest quiets the Grove and that's presented as *equally valid*, not as a lapse to correct.
- **Year to year:** the town accumulates *eras*. A cluster of landmarks from one year sits next to a sparser cluster from a harder year — both visible, both true, neither erased. This is the whole point: the town doesn't optimize itself into a highlight reel. It keeps the honest shape of a life.

What never changes: the underlying geography once placed, and every landmark ever earned. The town can go quiet. It never resets. Nothing is ever deleted for inactivity.

7. Seasons

Two layers, both light-touch:

- **Literal seasons** — the town's light and weather drift with the real calendar. Cosmetic, orienting, not gamified.
 - **Life seasons** — the deeper one. The system recognizes that intensity and rest are both normal parts of a life and lets districts breathe accordingly, rather than treating a quiet month as a broken streak to guilt someone back into. A busy season and a fallow season are just two different kinds of true.
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8. How the Brain celebrates

Quietly, specifically, and once. A short line in the companion's own voice — noticed, not announced. Never an interstitial screen, never a badge popup, never anything that asks you to stay in the app a beat longer than you already meant to.

The best celebration is one that happens *after* you've already put the phone down — you open Avora three days later for something unrelated, and the town has quietly changed since you were last here. The delight is discovery, not delivery.

9. The five-year feeling

Someone who's used Avora for five years shouldn't feel "productive." They should open it, rarely, and feel the particular quiet of recognizing their own life laid out in front of them — the year that was hard and looks hard, the year that was full and looks full, a handful of landmarks that still mean exactly what they meant when they were built, a district that's been fallow for two years because that part of life genuinely is, right now, and that's allowed to just be true without commentary.

The measure of success isn't time spent in the app. It's whether, five years in, the town feels less like *evidence of using Avora* and more like the person's actual life — witnessed, not gamified, not judged, kept.

10. What this rules out, on purpose

- No streaks, coins, XP, loot, or currency of any kind
- No decay, no guilt visuals, no "your town is sad" messaging
- No leaderboards, no comparison to other users, ever
- No push notifications designed to bring you back — the town changes *for* you, not *to summon* you
- No landmark, ever, for opening the app itself